



CHAMPIONS 2024

appear on the landing page even with the location set to Chennai.

A total of 500 tickets for the VIP stands were made public, with price tags starting at Rs 1499. These not only provided audiences a side-on view from close quarters but also had lucrative add-ons like a dinner buffet, a chance to interact with stars and win merchandise, and an opportunity to play a few rallies with Adam Bobrow or the ping-pong robot. But none of these added attractions found a mention on the booking application.

Crowds continued to be thin, except when Chennai Lions or Sathiyar's Dabang Delhi TTC played, with SDAT trainees occasionally filling seats courtesy of complimentary tickets.

"We need to have more publicity. I think people were happy watching

the stream. We are a largely improving sport. We should have more people come and experience it first. The ones who watched the grand show wanted to come again. You would have to bring them once, and then they would know the league is organised in the best way possible. I think that would really create a good image. It will get better in the coming seasons," an optimistic Sathiyar said.

A fault in the stars?

The two previous iterations had seen a better turnout, mostly because of the presence of a vibrant table tennis community in both cities. This year, JNIS saw an average footfall of 600 per match. This can also be attributed to the dwindling number of top foreigners as well. Six of the 12 international stars from the 2023 roster were missing this year.

Making history: Harmeet Desai catapulted the Goa Challengers to its second straight UTT title. It was the first time that the franchise-based table tennis league witnessed a two-time champion. **R RAGU**

World No. 13 Romanian Bernadette Szocs, who beat India's Archana Kamath 11-5, 8-11, 11-7, 11-9 during the women's team round of 16 match at the Olympics, was the highest-ranked player in the league, followed by Nigeria's Quadri Aruna (20).

Other prominent international stars included World Team Championships silver medallists Jules Rolland and Lilian Bardet of France, four-time Olympian Joao Monteiro of Portugal, and Spain's Alvaro Robles, a 2019 Worlds doubles silver medal